come to witness the parade and are accommodated within the NDA itself. My father caught up with his former Air Force colleagues and they quite forgot that they had come for their sons' passing out. I had explained to my father where I would be in the line-up so he could take photos at the appropriate moments. Unfortunately, while we were forming up in the Fort, my position was changed and my father ended up taking photos of the wrong person. Later, when I asked my parents whether they had seen me, they replied that actually, everyone looked so alike that they couldn't make out at all. Thus ended my stay at the NDA, as anonymously as it had begun. My pen-picture in the NDA yearbook sums it aptly, 'Kool Comfy snuck in and out of the squadron like a shy bat.'

After a break of four weeks or so, it was time to report to the Indian Military Academy (IMA) at Dehradun. The reception centre at the IMA was in the Cariappa Battalion Cadets' Mess, manned by a few of the Platoon Commanders. After unloading our trunks from the 3-Ton truck, I reported to the desk, which was being manned by Captain Avtar Singh of the Kumaon Regiment. On seeing me, he asked me to first wear a tie and then come back. I pointed out that the chap next to me wasn't wearing one either. Capt Avtar ticked me off—that chap, he said, was a 'Direct Entry, reporting for the first time. You are an ex-NDA and ought to know better'. Capt Avtar, it turned out, was the CM of my cousin Sanjay Naravane, who was then posted with the 14 Infantry Division at Clement Town. I was assigned to Alamein Company, which along with Sangro Company, was in the main blocks, the erstwhile Collins and Kingsley Blocks from pre-Independence times. I now became 15804/Alamein/66, Gentleman Cadet (GC) MM Naravane. Interestingly, all of us Naravanes—my uncle

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